WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

SAMOA

Oceania

Information current as of November 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Apia (Upolu)	Capital and commercial centre; seat of government and the Central Bank of Samoa, and site of the country's only international port, being upgraded with ADB support	Services, retail, construction, port logistics, ICT
Faleolo and north-west Upolu	International airport corridor linking Samoa with New Zealand, Australia, Fiji and the United States, with access to the Savai'i ferry	Aviation services, logistics, light manufacturing
Vaisigano catchment (Apia)	Site of a $99.7 million ADB-funded dam to reduce flood risk, secure water supply and cut emissions	Water, hydropower, construction, engineering
South and east Upolu coast	Main beach-resort coastline serving visitors from New Zealand, Australia and the United States	Resorts, eco-tourism, hospitality services
Savai'i	Largest island, with land for agriculture and nature-based tourism and a ferry and wharf link at Salelologa	Agriculture (coconut, taro, nonu), eco-tourism, fisheries
Exclusive Economic Zone	Ocean resources now overseen by a new Ministry of Fisheries and Marine Resources, with fishing operations open to up to 40% foreign equity	Tuna fishing and processing, aquaculture, cold chain

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- A Foreign Investment Certificate from the Ministry of Commerce, Industry and Labour under the Foreign Investment Act 2000, due within five working days and required before a business licence
- 100% foreign ownership is allowed in most sectors; a short reserved list (including retail, buses, taxis and car rental) is kept for citizens, and fishing and some coconut and nonu processing are restricted
- Priority sectors named by government include tourism, agro-processing, fisheries, ICT and business-process outsourcing, light manufacturing, renewable energy and creative industries
- A 27% corporate income tax, with Samoa removed from the EU list of non-cooperative tax jurisdictions in February 2026
- The tala is managed by the Central Bank of Samoa under a basket peg, which the IMF describes as an appropriate anchor; confirm repatriation procedures with the bank and commercial banks

- Leases of customary land, which makes up about 80% of land, typically for 30 years with renewal; freehold purchases by foreigners require the approval of the Head of State

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Samoa offers investors one of the strongest macroeconomic positions in the Pacific: public debt of just 18.1% of GDP in 2025/26, budget surpluses in each of the last two years and foreign reserves of about SAT$1.7 billion, equal to 15.7 months of imports in June 2026. Growth reached 4.2% in 2024/25, helped by hosting the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting in 2024, and inflation was only 1.0% in May 2026. Tourism and remittances are the twin pillars of the external accounts: visitor earnings rose 5.6% to SAT$377.2 million in July to December 2025, while remittances, led by Australia, New Zealand and the United States, reached SAT$478.1 million. Political stability improved after the August 2025 election gave the FAST party a clear majority under Prime Minister La'auli Leuatea Schmidt.

Samoa's main structural challenge is lifting growth in a small, remote economy with a narrow production base. The IMF estimates growth slowed to 0.4% in 2025/26 as consumption, private investment and agriculture weakened and higher oil prices took hold, and it projects a recovery to 2.0% in 2026/27, with inflation rising to around 4.5%. Labour shortages linked to migration to New Zealand and Australia and an ageing power network add to costs. The response is well funded: the 2026–27 budget of about SAT$1.5 billion raises development spending to SAT$215.9 million and sets aside SAT$100 million to secure fuel and power supply, while ADB grants for the Apia port and Vaisigano dam and new fisheries governance create openings in energy, infrastructure, agro-processing and tourism.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Slower growth and imported inflation	Growth slowed to 0.4% in 2025/26 and inflation is forecast to rise to around 4.5% on higher oil prices	Low debt and reserves of 15.7 months of imports give room for support; build fuel-cost scenarios and consider solar generation
Labour shortages	Only about 20% of the working-age population is formally employed, and migration has created gaps in tourism and health	Invest in training, partner with local institutions and plan staffing early; low wage costs remain an advantage
Customary land	About 80% of land is customary and cannot be sold or mortgaged, limiting its use as collateral	Use registered 30-year renewable leases with legal advice, and secure finance against project cash flows
Correspondent banking	Withdrawals of correspondent relationships have increased concentration risk for banks and money transfer operators	The IMF finds limited money-laundering threats in Samoa's remittance corridors; bank with established groups and keep strong compliance records
Infrastructure constraints	The power network is ageing and the only international port is congested	ADB-funded port, dam and solar projects are expanding capacity; plan logistics buffers and on-site power
Climate and disaster exposure	Cyclones, floods and tsunami risk affect coastal infrastructure and tourism	Build to resilient standards, use regional catastrophe insurance and target partner-funded adaptation projects
Governance and transparency	Public accounts have been delayed, and the Prime Minister's March 2026 acquittal in a criminal case is under appeal	A clear parliamentary majority, an independent judiciary and a national anti-corruption strategy support stability; engage through formal channels

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Samoa's risk profile is anchored by very low public debt, reserves of 15.7 months of imports, a basket-pegged currency endorsed by the IMF and a government with a clear parliamentary majority since the August 2025 election. The main near-term issues are a slowdown to 0.4% growth in 2025/26 and rising fuel-driven inflation, both being addressed through a larger 2026–27 budget, fuel and power support and continued grant financing

from the ADB and partners. Labour shortages, customary land rules and infrastructure bottlenecks are structural constraints that investors can manage with leases, training and careful logistics planning. Correspondent-banking pressures affect the region, although the IMF finds Samoa's remittance corridors present limited threats, and Samoa left the EU's tax non-cooperative list in February 2026. There are no international sanctions restricting investment in Samoa.

MARKET ACCESS

Samoa joined the WTO in 2012 and is a founding party to the Pacific Island Countries Trade Agreement (PICTA) and to PACER Plus, the regional trade and development agreement with Australia and New Zealand, which entered into force in December 2020. It acceded to the EU–Pacific interim Economic Partnership Agreement in 2018, giving duty-free, quota-free access to the EU, and its accession to the UK–Pacific agreement is pending. Older preference schemes such as SPARTECA and the US Generalised System of Preferences also apply. New Zealand, Australia and the United States are the main sources of visitors and remittances, and Faleolo International Airport and Apia port connect Samoa to these markets and to neighbouring American Samoa.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Prime Minister La'auli Leuatea Schmidt)	Leads the FAST government, sworn in on 16 September 2025 after the party won a clear majority, with two deputy prime ministers	Primary reference point for national priorities and major projects
Ministry of Commerce, Industry and Labour	Issues Foreign Investment Certificates, manages the reserved and restricted lists and handles investment promotion and labour matters	Standard first point of contact for market entry
Central Bank of Samoa	Manages the basket peg and monetary policy, holds reserves of 15.7 months of imports and supervises banks and money transfer operators	Key counterpart on banking, remittances and financial-sector entry
Ministry of Finance (Deputy Prime Minister Mulipola Anarosa Ale-Molio'o)	Leads the SAT$1.5 billion 2026–27 budget, tax policy, aid coordination and concessional lending	Relevant for incentives, duty concessions and co-financed projects
Samoa Tourism Authority	National tourism body marketing Samoa to New Zealand, Australia and the United States	Partner for resort and tourism investment
Electric Power Corporation	State power utility receiving most of the SAT$100 million fuel-supply response, with growing renewable generation	Counterpart for solar, storage and power-supply projects
Ministry of Fisheries and Marine Resources	Newly established ministry overseeing fisheries licensing and marine resources	Counterpart for fishing, processing and aquaculture ventures

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Samoa Chamber of Commerce and Industry is the main private-sector body and a channel for dialogue with government, alongside sector groups in tourism and manufacturing. The Asian Development Bank, with seven grants worth $232 million in its current Samoa portfolio, and the World Bank fund infrastructure, energy and resilience projects, while ADB private-sector finance has supported solar generation on Upolu. New Zealand, Australia, Japan, China and the EU are major development partners, and their missions in Apia provide useful introductions. Strong diaspora networks in New Zealand, Australia and the United States are a further channel for tourism, trade and investment links.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Samoa suits investors seeking a stable, low-debt Pacific base: resort and eco-tourism investors targeting visitors from New Zealand, Australia and the United States; agro-processors in coconut, nonu, cocoa and taro, and fishing

and aquaculture investors working with the new fisheries ministry; renewable energy and water investors aligned with ADB-backed projects; and light manufacturers and business-process outsourcing firms drawing on an English-speaking workforce and time-zone links to Australasia and the United States.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Obtain a Foreign Investment Certificate
Confirm the activity is not reserved or restricted and apply to the Ministry of Commerce, Industry and Labour before seeking a business licence.

STEP 2: Secure land through a registered lease
Negotiate a renewable lease of customary land with legal advice, or seek Head of State approval for any freehold purchase.

STEP 3: Arrange banking and repatriation
Open accounts with an established bank and confirm Central Bank of Samoa procedures for capital, dividends and supplier payments.

STEP 4: Plan staffing and training
Assess labour availability early, factor in the rising minimum wage and build training partnerships to address skills gaps.

STEP 5: Align with partner-funded projects
Map ADB, World Bank and bilateral programmes in ports, water, renewable energy and fisheries for supply and co-investment opportunities.